

Overview: Wait Time / Processing Time

Wait time is the deliberate pause between asking a question and expecting an answer. For pupils with processing difficulties, the standard 1-2 seconds most teachers wait is nowhere near enough. By extending wait time to 5-10 seconds (or longer), you give their brains time to decode the question, retrieve relevant information, formulate a response, and prepare to speak. This single adjustment can transform a pupil who "never answers" into one who participates confidently.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil rarely or never volunteers answers
- Gives correct answers when given time, but freezes in whole-class questioning
- Says "I don't know" immediately, then gives correct answer later
- Appears to "zone out" during question-and-answer sessions

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Establish a "thinking time" signal

Create a clear signal that tells the whole class "we are now thinking, not answering." This normalises the pause and takes pressure off the target pupil.

Teacher says: "When I hold up my hand like this, it means thinking time. No hands up yet. Everyone is thinking."

Tip: A visual signal (hand up, "thinking" card, timer) works better than just saying "think".

2 Ask the question clearly

State the question once, clearly. Don't rephrase or add to it during thinking time.

Teacher says: "What was the main reason the character felt angry?" [Raises hand signal]

Tip: Rephrasing during thinking time resets the processing clock to zero.

3 Count silently to 10

Count slowly in your head: "one-thousand-one, one-thousand-two..." up to at least 10. This feels longer than you expect. That's normal.

Tip: It will feel awkward at first. Push through. The silence is productive.

4 Scan the room calmly

While waiting, look around the room with a neutral expression. Don't stare at the target pupil. Don't show impatience.

Tip: Your body language during wait time matters. Looking rushed makes pupils feel rushed.

5 Invite responses

After thinking time, lower your hand signal and invite responses. If using cold-calling, give the named pupil a few more seconds after being named.

Teacher says: "Thinking time is over. [Name], what do you think?"

Tip: If the pupil still needs time, say "I'll come back to you" rather than moving on permanently.

English Example: Comprehension discussion

Year 9 discussing a poem. One pupil with processing difficulties rarely participates in discussions.

Step 1: Set up thinking time

Teacher: Say: "I'm going to ask a question. When you see my hand up, that's thinking time. No calling out."

Pupil: Listens. Understands the signal.

Step 2: Ask and wait

Teacher: Say: "Why do you think the poet chose to repeat the word 'silence'?" Raises hand. Counts silently to 12.

Pupil: Processes the question. Thinks about the poem. Starts forming an answer.

Step 3: Invite response

Teacher: Lowers hand. Says: "Jamie, I'd like to hear your thinking." Waits 5 more seconds.

Pupil: Says: "Because... it makes you notice it more?"

Maths Example: Mental arithmetic

Year 7 practising times tables. Pupil knows the answers when given time but freezes in rapid-fire questioning.

Step 1: Change the format

Teacher: Say: "We're going to do times tables differently today. I'll ask, then we all get thinking time."

Pupil: Listens. Feels less anxious knowing there will be time.

Step 2: Ask with extended wait

Teacher: Say: "Seven times eight." Shows thinking time signal. Counts slowly to 8.

Pupil: Counts mentally: 7, 14, 21, 28, 35, 42, 49, 56.

Step 3: Call on pupil

Teacher: Say: "Aisha, what did you get?" Waits 3 more seconds.

Pupil: Says: "Fifty-six." Feels successful.

Science Example: Explaining a concept

Year 8 learning about photosynthesis. Pupil understands concepts but needs time to put understanding into words.

Step 1: Preview the question

Teacher: Say: "I'm going to ask you to explain what the plant needs for photosynthesis. Take a moment to think."

Pupil: Starts thinking before the formal question.

Step 2: Ask and wait

Teacher: Say: "What three things does a plant need for photosynthesis?" Waits 10 seconds with thinking signal.

Pupil: Recalls: sunlight, water, carbon dioxide. Rehearses the words mentally.

Step 3: Support the response

Teacher: Says: "Tell me one to start." Waits 5 seconds.

Pupil: Says: "Sunlight." Gains confidence.